

MBA: 8109 RESEARCH METHODS



Session 1 — Introduction: Foundations for Your Dissertation Journey

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Strathmore Business School | MBA Evening 2026, Trimester II



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WHY THIS COURSE MATTERS

More Than a Unit on Your Transcript

- Every MBA candidate must produce a Project, Dissertation or Thesis to graduate.
- This course builds the exact skills your dissertation will demand — topic, problem literature, design, ethics, analysis, writing.
- The Chapter 1 you draft here becomes the real Chapter 1 of your dissertation.
- Skip it or rush it now, and you relearn it later — under supervision, on the clock, with less room to fail.

2

THE REAL STAKES

What Happens After This Course

- Passing this course properly is your ticket to supervisor allocation.
- Strathmore allocates supervisors within one month of completing Research Methods.
- Struggle here, delay your Chapter 1, and that clock simply does not start.

No solid Research Methods pass → No supervisor → No dissertation progress.

3

BEFORE WE BEGIN

Ground Rules for This Course

- Be present and on time — 5:30pm sharp, every session.
- Come with YOUR Study interest — we work on real ideas, not hypotheticals.
- Come with your PC always, do personal reading and practices
- Deadlines are fixed — the CAT and concept-paper dates do not move.
- Full participation — syndicate work is graded engagement, not attendance.
- Zero tolerance for plagiarism, ethical use of AI from your very first paragraph.
- Respect the room and FOCUS— having your computers open when required, phones down- only, when necessary, full professional conduct.



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SET YOUR EXPECTATIONS

Challenges Students Commonly Face

- Choosing ONE feasible topic, not ten exciting ones.
- Balancing full-time work against research demands.
- Weak literature-search and academic-writing habits.
- Uncertainty over which methodology and design to choose.
- Getting real access to organisations and respondents.
- Delays in obtaining ethical clearance.



5

THE COST OF FALLING BEHIND

Setbacks of Not Completing on Time

- Supervisor allocation is delayed until this course is properly completed.
- Extensions require fees, paperwork and Dean-level approval.
- A maximum study period is enforced — exceed it, and you are de-registered.
- Missed course cohorts mean missed graduation dates.

Time lost at this stage is rarely recovered later in the programme.





READ THIS TWICE

Why a Noble Idea Still Fails

- A brilliant idea with no feasible design will not survive proposal defence.
- Data collected before ethical clearance = automatic disqualification. No exceptions.
- Objectives that don't match your problem statement get sent back for rewrite.
- Your entire study need to be in sync from the topic to the recommendations
- Formatting and structure that ignore the SU Guide will not be accepted for examination.

Rigour — +/-not novelty — innovation is what carries you through to graduation.

6

GROUNDING THE STUDY AREA

What Is Business & Management Research?

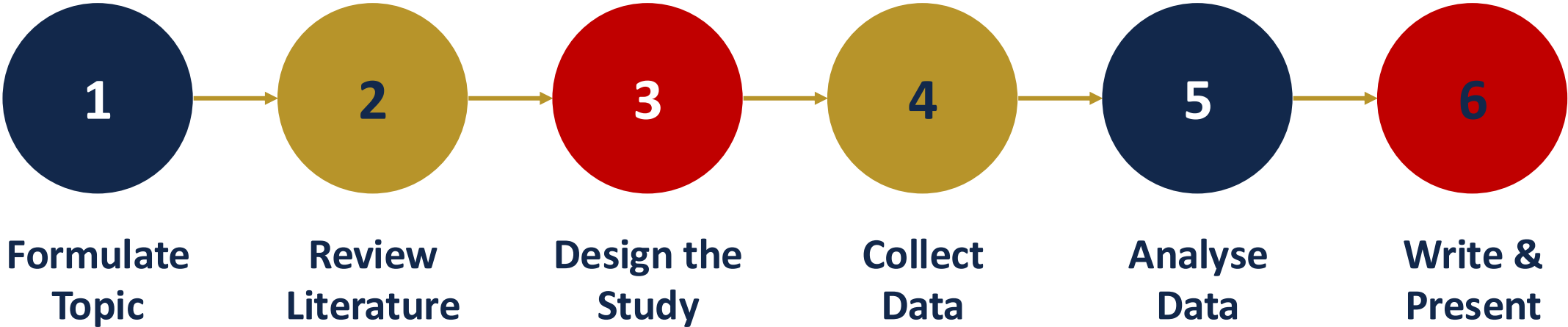


- Research is systematic enquiry that increases knowledge (Saunders, Lewis & Thornhill, Ch. 1).
- It is deliberate investigation — distinct from opinion, assumption or anecdote.
- Business research applies this same discipline to solve real organisational problems.

7

THE ROAD AHEAD

The Research Process, Start to Finish



Every stage matters — a weak start (topic, philosophy) undermines everything after it.

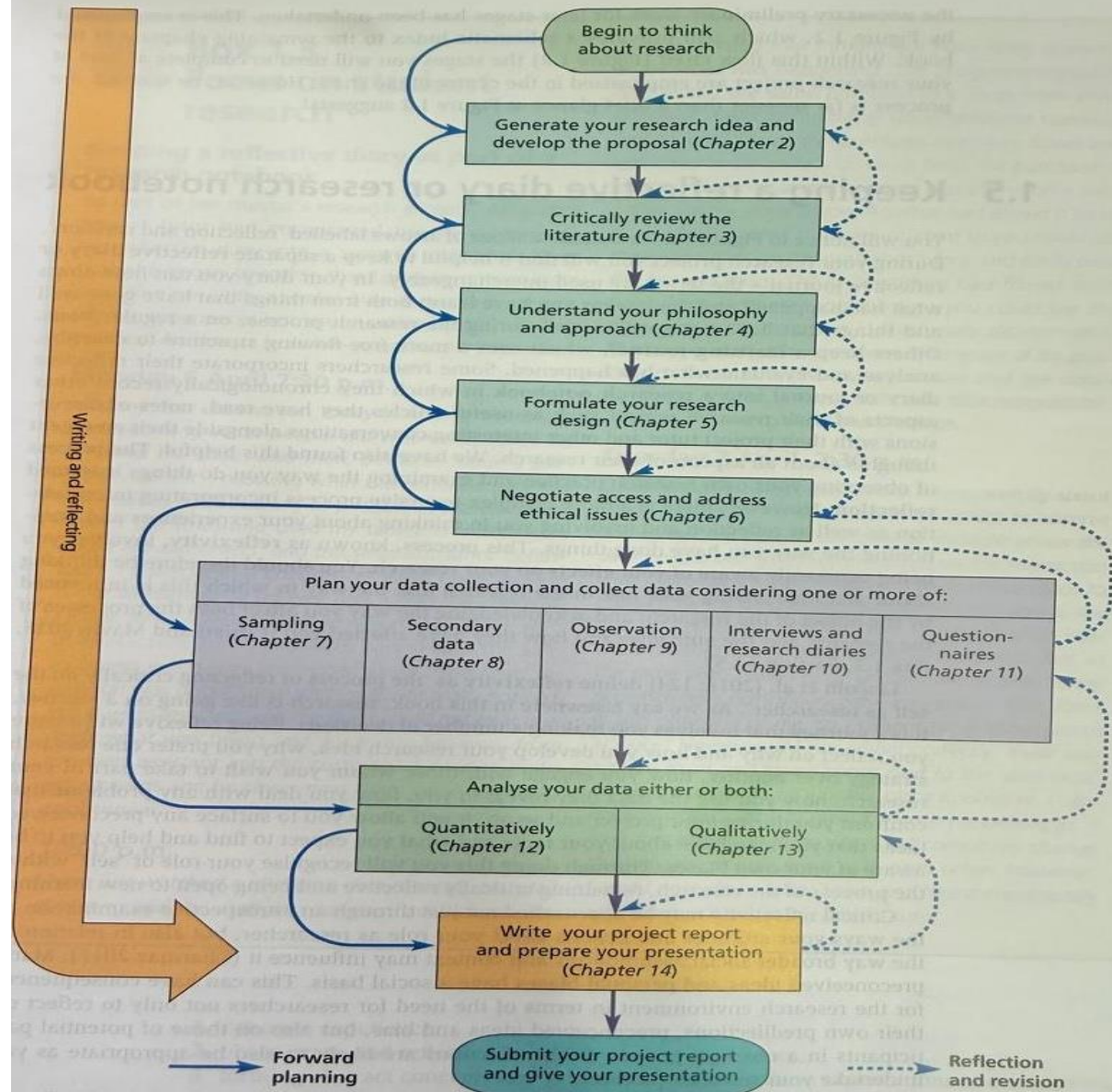


Figure 1.2 The research process

Source: © Mark Saunders, Philip Lewis and Adrian Thornhill 2022

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KNOW YOUR OUTPUT

Which One Applies to You?

Research Project

Certificates & Diplomas

Length: 12,000–15,000 words

Duration: ~3 months

Dissertation

MBA & conversion Master's

Length: 20,000–25,000 words

Duration: 3–6 months

Thesis

Academic Master's

Length: 25,000–50,000 words

Duration: 6–12 months

YOUR PATH

9

YOUR TURN

Naming a Study Area

- Think of an industry, organisation or problem you know well.
- Write one sentence: “I am curious about ____ because ____.”
- Keep it broad for now — we narrow it together over the coming weeks.



Bring this sentence to Week 2 — it is the seed of your Chapter 1.

What You Will Leave With

- A complete, examined Chapter 1 draft (your CAT).
- Worked as a syndicate to establish what really a research work is for Strathmore
- A concept paper ready to carry into proposal writing.
- Working knowledge of Strathmore's ethics application process.
- A clear model of what a passing Strathmore dissertation looks like.



Your Reference Toolkit

- Prescribed text: Saunders, Lewis & Thornhill — Research Methods for Business Students.
- Strathmore Guide to Research for Postgraduate Theses, Dissertations & Projects.
- SU+ Digital Repository — real, examined Strathmore dissertations to learn from.
- APA referencing style — non-negotiable, from your very first citation.



13 WHAT DECIDES THE OUTCOME

Critical Success Factors — and Common Setbacks

Critical success factors

- A focused, researchable question — narrow enough to answer with the data you can actually access.
- Steady weekly progress and a realistic timeline, with milestones agreed with your supervisor.
- Disciplined reading and referencing from day one, so the literature review writes itself.
- Method fits the question; ethics approval and data access secured early.

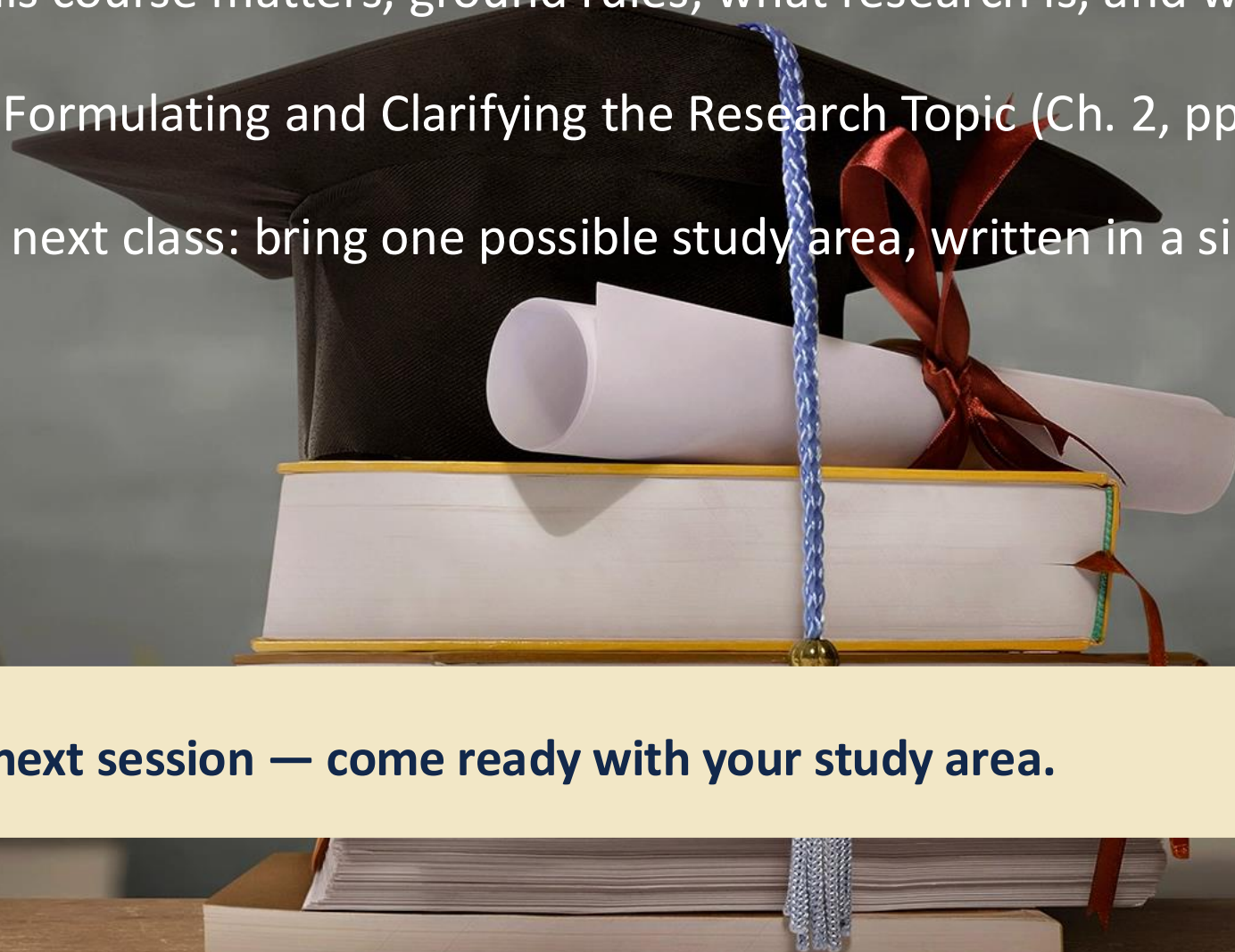
Common setbacks

- Topic too broad or shifting; low response rates and poor-quality or inaccessible data.
- Underestimating time, weak supervisor contact, and writing left to the final weeks.
- Analysis and findings that drift away from the original research objectives.

Most dissertations fail on planning and scope, not on intelligence.

Recap and Next Steps

- Today: why this course matters, ground rules, what research is, and what lies ahead.
- Next session: Formulating and Clarifying the Research Topic (Ch. 2, pp. 20–57).
- Action before next class: bring one possible study area, written in a single sentence.

A black graduation cap with a blue tassel sits on a stack of books. A rolled-up white diploma tied with a red ribbon is tucked behind the cap. The background is a blurred bookshelf.

See you next session — come ready with your study area.